

students currently are from the 'Covid batches', having spent two to three years learning online. They haven't experienced the usual classroom challenges or face-to-face interaction, and now they're suddenly thrust into an intense B-school environment that requires a high level of involvement. This presents a new challenge, both from the faculty's and the students' perspectives.

THE BIG FUNDING CHALLENGE

The government has not stopped funds for infrastructure, at least for the newer or the baby IIMs. For this, different discussions are taking place within institutes. While we are growing, we need infrastructural support, and the only option is to take loans. A silver lining is the government's Higher Education Funding

Agency, which offers loans at a competitive interest rate of 5.5%.

IIMs already charge substantial fees, and increasing fees would not be fair. Increasing the number of students poses two issues: first, we don't have enough infrastructure to accommodate them; and second, we don't want to compromise on quality. Quantity and quality often don't go hand in hand. This is why we need to focus on executive education. That's where our revenue generation lies, and, to my knowledge, every IIM is focussing on this area, especially online.

The certificate programmes are also under focus. Many institutions have been running these programmes because it's a low-hanging fruit and require minimal logistics. It's convenient for everyone, especially for professionals in the manufacturing industry with 7-10 years of experience who have not had the opportunity to receive high-quality education. By offering them affordable education, we meet a crucial need.

Edtech platforms play an important role in managing participant enrollment. They are responsible for managing a team of counsellors, spending heavily on social media marketing. If a programme doesn't attract enough participants, they take a hit, which is risky.

Revision of curricula is important. We have a policy to review our curriculum every three to four years through a dedicated committee. In 2021, we updated our regular MBA and PhD curricula. We didn't just rely on internal insights but also invited two eminent professors from older IIMs to contribute. Based on their inputs, we introduced a course called Experiential Learning.

Finally, it's not just about teaching. We need to be adaptive—not only to technology, but also to other changes around us, including addressing issues like mental health challenges. **BT**

*The author is Dean
(Development), IIM Kashipur.
Views are personal*

